

Effects of Incarceration onHealth

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The Prison Health Link

Every year more than half a million inmates are released from prison back into society. The health implications of incarceration are profound; this research seeks to gather a greater understanding of how incarceration effects the quality of health of ex-inmates. The project consists of interviews collected from ex-inmates, these interviews focus on the life experiences inmates face after incarceration. Transcription and analysis of these interviews will give further understanding and support to the research revealing the link between health and incarceration. For every person leaving the prison system there is a story; this project begins to tell that story.

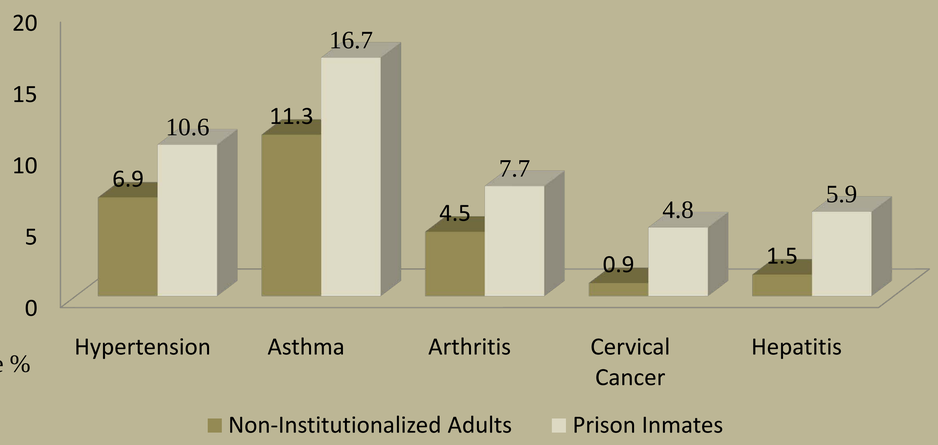
Minnesota Exits and Entries Project Overview

The primary research focus of this project is qualitative analysis of the data collected in the Minnesota Exits and Entries Project (MEEP). MEEP is a data set collected from persons exiting and entering different institutions. These institutions consist of the military, foster care, adult prisons, juvenile correction facilities, and mental health facilities. The focus of my project centers on persons who are exiting the prison system.

Methodology

In addition to analyzing some of the existing scholarship regarding the prison health link, this analysis focused deeply on interviews from the MEEP project. I transcribed interviews from persons transitioning out of the prison system. These interviews are valuable because they help us make sense of the link between incarceration and health care. Interviewees talk about life experiences leaving prison that can contribute to lower health. These experiences include, unemployment, underemployment, lack of education, poverty, alcoholism, narcotics, etc. Understanding these stories help further understand the prison health link and can contribute to better healthcare and prison policies.

Weighted Prevalence of Chronic Conditions in Non-institutionalized adults and Prison inmates.



The data indicates the prevalence of chronic conditions in both non-institutionalized adults and prison inmates. Prison inmates have a much higher rate of chronic illnesses. Notice the prevalence Cervical Cancer and Hepatitis which is rare amongst non-institutionalized adults but much more prevalent amongst prison inmates.

Basic Associations in Health Functioning: The Effect of Incarceration and Life Course Markers on Mental and Physical Health.



Education, employment and marriage all have a positive effects on both physical and mental health. Exposure to the prison system and substance abuse have a strong negative impact on both physical and mental health.

Discussion

The U.S. Ex-felon population was estimated at about 11.7 million people. This represents 9% of all adults. With such a huge population serving felony sentences or living with felony convictions it is essential that we understand the effects of these convictions. These effects are clearly seen in the health disparities between the general population and those who serve time in prison.

Quotes from Interviews:

"I am a three time burglar felon and most places that I apply to they think I'm going to rob them. That's really, really hard. The only place that I can think of that will hire on the spot is construction and temp jobs-easiest to go right there."

"The legal system is literally bullshit. But once your in it your in it. You cant get out"

"The way I dealt with problems growing up was just to use to get away from reality and be in my own little reality. And… Reality never changes; its always there. You can get a temporary fix and smoke a joint and whatever. Take a couple drinks. But its just a temporary fix. Once you get a come down or whatever, or wake up from you hangover. It all comes back to you"

Conclusion

Study of the Minnesota Exits and Entries Project tells a story. This story is very important given the growing number of those who are currently incarcerated or living with criminal convictions. Just recently in 2008 the U.S. Department of justice estimated that about 100 million people in the United States had criminal records. With such an enormous number of people coming into contact with the Criminal Justice System it is essential that we understand how these people are affected by this system both directly and indirectly. The health disparities between non-institutionalized adults and prison inmates give a clear picture that incarceration has effects that reach far beyond the prison walls. Understanding the prison health link will contribute to better prison policy and better health policy. This project tells a story that will further that understanding.

Table 1: Binswanger Ingrid, Krueger Patrick, Steiner John. *"Prevalence of Chronic Medical Conditions among Jail and Prison Inmates in the United States Compared with the General Population."*

Table 2: Massoglia Michael. 2005. *"The Mid-Life Health Consequences of Crime and Punishment."* 203, 206.

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